

Obama's Victory was Backed by Open Source Technology!

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When US president Barack Obama and his tech-savvy team started using Drupal and Linux to run websites back in 2009, concerns were raised all over the world. Those who favoured the proprietary system were of the opinion that resorting to open source technology could turn out to be one of the biggest mistakes of the Obama administration. Since then, the White House website is running a typical LAMP (Linux, Apache, MySQL and PHP) stack to support Drupal. The credit for bringing in the new Linux-based infrastructure goes to GDIT (General Dynamics Information Technology), an IT contractor for the US government.

This was not the only incidence of Obama banking on open source technology. One would find it hard to believe but open source technology played a crucial role in his win. The

recently held presidential elections in the US were not just a battle of ideologies but also a duel between the IT strategies and tools of the two parties. Obama's IT technology team's use of open source technology proved to be much more effective than Romney's expensive IT infrastructure.

Obama's tech team employed open source technology on services and consulting not only to save funds but to create a more efficient infrastructure. According to some online reports, Obama's internal IT back-up cost him \$9.3 million, while his competitor Romney spent around \$23.6 million on mostly proprietary technology services. And the entire world has witnessed how Obama's architecture outperformed Romney's costly IT campaign.

Obama's tech team mostly depended on Linux. To be precise, Ubuntu was deployed on the server as the chief operating system. "We used the right technology in the right place," said Scott VanDenPlas, lead DevOps for Obama for America. The team developed around 200 applications in Python, Ruby, PHP, Java and Node.js.

The Obama administration, in its first tenure, issued guidelines for using open source technology in critical sectors such as defence as well. In a DoD (Department of Defence) Clarifying Guidance Regarding Open Source Software memo, the CIO declared, "To effectively achieve its missions, the Department of Defense must develop and update its software-based capabilities faster than ever, to anticipate new threats and respond to continuously changing requirements. The use of Open Source Software (OSS) can provide advantages in this regard."

It's not just Obama and his tech team that is recognising the power of open source technology. Open source is spreading its wings far and wide. Canonical's Ubuntu Linux distribution, which is very popular in the desktop environment, is slowly gaining space in Web server deployment also. If the data available online is to be believed, seven per cent of Web servers globally run Ubuntu compared to 5.5 per cent last year. UNIX is used by 64.2 per cent of all websites. Seven per cent might seem low but when compared to the 3.4 per cent that Red Hat holds, the 1.2 per cent of Red Hat's community-maintained Fedora, and only 0.8 per cent for SUSE, the figure seems to be quite promising and shows that open source technology is being actively adopted across the globe. 

By: OSFY Bureau